

CA/Browser Forum Tracker

Part 4 - Public Trust Programs

Compiled by the Spaced Research Ledger

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The Forum writes the rules, and the root programs decide who is trusted. That division matters because a root program can and does impose requirements the Baseline Requirements do not, often a year or more ahead of them. This part covers both halves of that enforcement layer. Section 1 covers the four browser and operating system root store policies. Section 2 covers the Common CA Database and the incident and distrust record that runs through it.

Two kinds of distrust appear below and should never be conflated. One follows a pattern of misconduct and is punitive. The other follows the age of a root and is routine housekeeping. Both remove trust, and only one is a judgment about a certificate authority's behaviour.

1. Root Store Policies

Four organizations run root programs that matter for the public web. Their policies are converging on the same themes, which are dedicated hierarchies, bounded root lifetimes, and stronger evidence of what a certificate authority actually does.

Recent Developments

Mozilla Root Store Policy version 3.1 was published on 29 June 2026 and took effect on 1 July 2026 [1] [2]. Its theme is transparency and assurance. It revises Section 3.3 to require that policy and practice statement documentation be explicit, bounded, auditable and detailed enough to describe issuance activities. It adds requirements for version control, accessibility and maintenance [1].

The most consequential change in that policy arrives later. For audit periods beginning on or after 1 July 2027, certificate authorities with roots enabled for TLS website authentication must obtain a Detailed Controls Report [3]. That report must cover system scope, audit criteria, implemented controls, testing procedures, test results and any deficiencies [3]. Version 3.1 also requires root key pairs to have been generated within the previous five years. It aligns mass revocation planning with the Forum's requirements, and clarifies notification when ownership or operational control changes [1] [4].

The Chrome Root Program Policy is at version 1.8, last updated 5 February 2026 [5]. It limits the number of root certificates per certificate authority owner and extends automation support to all existing authorities. It also requires policy documents to state adherence explicitly, and sets expectations for industry engagement [5]. Owners with more than two self-signed roots in the Chrome Root Store had to submit a consolidation plan before 15 June 2026. A maximum of two self-signed roots per owner takes effect on 15 September 2027 [6].

Two further programs published requirements this year. Microsoft's Trusted Root Program requirements took effect on 1 July 2026. They cap newly minted root authorities at ten years of validity from submission, and require participating roots to be dedicated to clearly defined trust purposes [7].

Apple's root program policy took effect on 1 August 2026. It requires subordinate certificates to carry an Extended Key Usage extension and forbids asserting anyExtendedKeyUsage. Externally operated subordinate authorities need Apple approval before issuance [8].

Current State

All four programs are moving against multi-purpose roots. Mozilla requires new roots to be dedicated to either TLS or S/MIME. Operators had until 15 April 2026 to submit a transition plan for existing dual-purpose roots, and must complete migration to separate roots by 31 December 2028 [9]. Chrome requires that hierarchies in its store be dedicated solely to TLS server authentication, with the phase-out for existing authorities beginning 15 June 2026 [5].

Chrome also publishes a document of stated direction rather than binding rules. Moving Forward, Together names support for automation, term limits for roots, and minimum linting expectations. It also names phasing out multi-purpose roots and client authentication use cases, strengthening domain validation, and shorter validity for subordinate and subscriber certificates [10]. It carries no implementation timelines of its own, and its items bind only when they appear in the policy itself or in a Forum ballot [11]. Two proposals sit there without dates, which are rotating aging roots rather than trusting them for thirty years or more, and bounding the currently unlimited lifetime of subordinate certificates [12].

Unresolved Conflicts

The record contains an unresolved inconsistency about Chrome policy versions. One source attributes the June 2026 dedicated-hierarchy requirement to version 1.6, while the policy document itself is version 1.8 dated 5 February 2026 [5]. A version 1.8 dated February cannot postdate a version 1.6 dated June, so at least one of those attributions is wrong. Reading the policy archive in order would settle which requirement entered at which version. The requirement and its June 2026 date are not in doubt, only the version that introduced it.

2. The Common CA Database, Incidents and Distrust

The database is where certificate authorities disclose what they operate, and the incident bugs are where their behaviour is judged. Together they form the behavioural record that root programs act on.

Recent Developments

CCADB Policy version 2.1 took effect on 20 March 2026 [13]. It requires certificate authority policy documents to state adherence to the CCADB Policy from 15 September 2026, and encourages focused single-use-case policy documents [14]. The database itself gained new fields on the same date. They include a JSON array of all full revocation list URLs, plus automation attestation and public test infrastructure fields for root records. An Apple policy agreement field was added to inclusion requests [15].

Further changes are proposed rather than adopted. The CCADB Steering Committee has put forward clarifications on subordinate authority ownership disclosure. It also proposes further policy document disclosures from 15 September 2026, audit sampling disclosure for periods beginning 15 January 2027, and qualified auditor involvement in incident reports [16]. The self-assessment template moved to version 1.8 on 26 February 2026 [17].

The most visible trust removal this year was routine rather than punitive. On 15 April 2026 Mozilla and Chrome removed the DigiCert G1 generation of roots, and certificates chaining solely to them lost trust in Firefox and Chrome that day [18]. Three roots were affected, and dependent certificates had to move to the G2 or G3 roots [19]. This was an age-based retirement in support of modern cryptographic standards, not a response to misconduct [20]. Mozilla made other lifecycle-driven removals in its April 2026 release, including a websites trust bit removal for Izenpe [21].

Current State

The punitive precedent remains Entrust. Google was the first root program to act, citing a pattern of concerning behaviours rather than any single incident [22]. Chrome applied the distrust gradually rather than as an immediate cutoff. Certificates logged to a Certificate Transparency log before a defined enforcement date stayed trusted until they expired [23]. That blocking action took effect on 12 November 2024, timed to the Chrome M131 release [24].

Mozilla stopped trusting Entrust certificates dated after 30 November 2024, leaving earlier ones in place [25]. Distrust in this ecosystem is applied by issuance date rather than by mass revocation.

The incident regime is continuous rather than episodic. A certificate authority that suffers an incident must file a report on Bugzilla that is detailed, candid, timely and transparent. The quality of that report is itself part of what root programs judge [26]. Open bugs during 2026 included NETLOCK non-compliance with the CCADB incident reporting guidelines [27]. Others covered profile deviations in a CFCA responder certificate found in April 2026, and a D-Trust report with an action item due 30 September 2026 [28].

Policy is argued in public before it is adopted. Mozilla's proposed updates on root authority life cycles went to the dev-security-policy mailing list, which remains the venue for that debate [29]. The same list carried 2026 discussion of the version 3.1 audit improvements and responses to a May 2026 survey of certificate authorities [30].

About This Report

The Spaced Research Ledger is an automated system that gathers claims from live public sources, checks each one against its origin, and records every disagreement instead of merging it. Every stage runs on a different AI model, drawn from three to four systems across competing labs, so no single model both finds a claim and judges it. The Spaced Research Ledger is designed and maintained by Ridley DiSiena.

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